

erupting almost daily, and regularly sending ash 16,000 ft (5,000m) into the sky. Its summit has three peaks, but since 2006 activity has centered on the Showa crater, east of the Minami-dake summit.

## The Tianzi Mountains

**Location** Hunan province, China

The Tianzi Mountain Nature Reserve is part of the spectacular Wulingyuan Scenic Area, whose main claim to fame is more

than 3,000 quartzite sandstone columns, many of which are more than 660 ft (200m) tall. There are also ravines, caves, fast-flowing streams, and waterfalls. Lush forest covers the area, which is often shrouded in mist and fog. The columns are the product of water eroding vertical joints in the 380-million-year-old sandstone.

## The Tibetan Plateau

**Location** Mostly in China (Tibet) and India, Central and East Asia

This is the world's largest and highest plateau, a vast area of flat or undulating steppe about five times the area of France and on average 14,800 ft (4,500m) above sea level. Bordered to the south by the Himalayas, to the north by the Kunlun Mountains, and to the northeast by the Qilian Range, the plateau supports tens of thousands of glaciers and is the source of the several major rivers, including the Indus and Brahmaputra.



▲ VIOLENT ERUPTION ON THE SHOWA CRATER OF SAKURAJIMA

## Baishuitai Hot Springs and Terraces

**Location** Yunnan province, China

Also known as the White Water Terraces, Baishuitai is located high in the uplands of Yunnan, in the foothills of the Haba Snow Mountains. It has some of the world's most beautiful terraces of travertine (a form of calcium carbonate). Water from geothermal springs pours over hundreds of white semicircular steps and terraces, which cover an area 460 ft (140 m) long and 520 ft (160 m) wide. The high concentrations of calcium carbonate in the water precipitate out at lower temperatures to leave behind the travertine. The terraces are one of the sacred sites of the Dongba culture.

## The Huangshan Mountains

**Location** Anhui province, China

Celebrated for their beauty in art and literature for hundreds of years (for example, in the Shanshui, or "mountain and water," style of painting), the Huangshan Mountains feature oddly shaped pines, towering granite peaks and cliffs,

waterfalls, lakes, and forests, all sometimes draped in mist. There are 77 peaks exceeding 3,300 ft (1,000 m), with Lian Hua Feng (Lotus Flower Peak) reaching 6,115 ft (1,864 m). Many pines grow from fissures in the rock faces, and 19 plant species are endemic to the mountains. Also called The Yellow Mountains, the Huangshan Mountains were listed as a World Heritage Site by UNESCO in 1990.

## Mayon Volcano

**Location** In the south of the island of Luzon, the Philippines

This is the most active volcano in the Philippines, having erupted at least 49 times in the last 400 years. Rising 8,077 ft (2,462 m) above the Abay Gulf, this stratovolcano is considered to be one of the most perfectly symmetrical in the world. Mayon's most violent eruption, in 1814, killed over 1,200 people and ended up devastating several towns. Following another eruption in 2006, heavy typhoon rainfall produced lahars (mudflows) from the recently deposited ash, which killed at least 1,000 people.

